eliminating overreliance on any one individual or a certain group of individuals.

◆

Meanwhile, only in late February had China admitted that 2,236 people had succumbed to the virus in Wuhan.[9] Even while the accuracy of the number was debated amongst epidemiologists and scientists, nations in Europe including the United Kingdom (UK), were just about upgrading risk levels to 'moderate' from 'low'. These were perhaps Europe's final days of innocence—in Codogno, a small town in Lombardy, north Italy, doctors had just started to treat a man suffering respiratory symptoms, with zero suspicion that there was anything unusual.[10] In less than a month, pictures and videos in the media showed horrifying signs from the streets of Italy displaying a nation in crisis, convulsed by fear, in the tight grip of the new disease. The rise of the cases was so swift that the healthcare system quickly became distressed to a point where doctors had to make the gut-wrenching choice of which patient presenting in the emergency ward had a higher chance of survival over admitting those with a low probability. The sick were either abandoned in their homes or lying on the hospital floors.[11] Soon, Lombardy would be completely locked down, being one of the first cities in the western world to use the 'physical suppression' method to stop the spread of the infection.[12] Being jolted into the reality that the COVID-19 threat was very real, countries like the UK updated their mathematical models and arrived at a new 'reasonable worst-case scenario' where about 80 per cent of Britons would be eventually infected, out of which one per cent would die. With mitigation measures, the team of scientists from the UK's Scientific Advisory Group for Emergencies concurred that the death toll could reach 2,50,000 and the existing intensive care units (ICUs) would be overwhelmed eight times over when the virus spreads in the community. However, the UK government took a more modest view and its National Security Communications Team warned that with 80 per cent of the population infected, 'the current planning assumption is that 2–3 percent of symptomatic cases will result in a fatality.'[13] With this statistic, they said, 'the country planned to create some kind of herd immunity, whereby a large proportion of the population has had the virus and is therefore inoculated [which] is clearly the objective—well, not the objective; rather, it is one of